Candelabra

Philip Greenwood turns an elegant candelabra from three pieces of timber

PHOTOGRAPHS BY WENDY GREENWOOD

PHILIP GREENWOOD

Philip has been turning wood since 1980 and started turning professionally in 1986. He was accepted onto the Register of Professional Turners (RPT) in 2006. He is also a member of the AWGB. He can be seen working in his workshop in North Yorkshire and has demonstrated at the woodworking show at Harrogate since 2008. He runs courses at his workshop.

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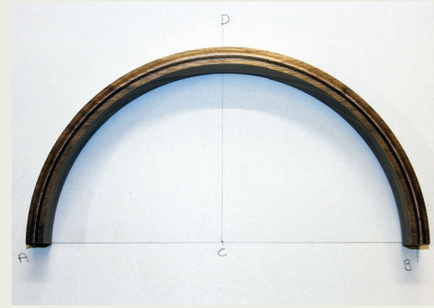
This candelabra is made from three pieces of timber; the base could be made from the centre of the circular disc that makes up the arms, but here a separate piece is used to make the base. A small piece is used for the stem between the base and the arms. The arms are joined together with the small stem, which has a spigot to fit in the base and the bottom of the arm sections. You could just use half of the circle to make a two-candle holder instead of this one; you just need an extra stem and base pieces, then you have two candle holders. There are two main points to consider when turning the circle that will make the arms. Firstly, when you reverse the disc on the chuck, make sure it runs true, and secondly make sure that the designs on both sides match each other or it will be very noticeable when the ring is cut in half and looking down on the section of the arm, you can use a template to check both sides match.

Give careful thought to the safety aspect when making an item that can hold candles which may or may not be lit, especially if you sell the candelabra – you don't know what the customer will do, so that is why I always use a metal or glass liner on any item I make that holds candles. The timber I used was an offcut from a plank that was used on a previous project. The finish was one coat of cellulose sanding sealant. This was finished with a three-part mop buffing system, the final coat was carnauba wax. This process is best carried out before assembly, buffing each component separately, trying to avoid any part that will be glued.

MARKING A HOLE ON A TURNED CIRCLE

How many times have you drilled a hole in the top of a half circle only to find it was off-centre? Use this method to make sure the hole is always in the centre. All you need is a piece of paper or card. Draw a line the same length as the width of the half circle, let's call the ends A and B, and then divide this into half. Now draw a line at 90° at this halfway point at least the height of the half circle, let's call this C and D. Next, lay the turned item on this paper making sure the ends line up on the A and B line. At point D mark a point on the item, this is the mid-way point, you just need to make sure it is in the middle of the width as well. Then drill on this point. If you're using a pillar drill, make sure the table is at 90° to the drill bit, if you're using a hand-held drill use a set square to make sure you drill at 90° in both planes.



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